

LIVE



NEWSPAPER

17th October, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

42nd WEEK



SOMALIA & AL-SHABAAB

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS.

UPSC CSE – GS III

GS III... LINKAGES OF ORGANIZED CRIME WITH TERRORISM.



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

17th OCTOBER, 2017

1

Securing Somalia

The deadly attack in Mogadishu is a reminder that state-building must be accelerated

The deadliest terrorist attack in Somalia, an explosives-laden truck collided with a fuel tanker in Mogadishu, killing more than 100 people and injuring many more. Mogadishu has seen a number of attacks and suicide bombings on "soft targets", mainly hotels and restaurants, and military targets, orchestrated by the terrorist group al-Shabab in recent years, but none as horrific as this one. The Islamist organisation has not yet claimed responsibility for the attacks, but government spokespersons have blamed the al-Qaeda-affiliated group. A weakened al-Shabab has managed to revive itself since guerrilla force lately. Reports suggest that it has not claimed responsibility for Sunday's attacks as yet because of the scale of the toll, as it did not anticipate the truck colliding with a fuel tanker. If it is indeed al-Shabab's doing, it would signal a dangerous reversal. Somalia must immediately work towards building a sense of civic solidarity among the various clans in the country and use the popular revulsion following the bombing to isolate al-Shabab and its backers. al-Shabab had retreated from Mogadishu in August 2011 following intense joint offensives led by the African Union Mission in Somalia (AMISOM) and the Somali federal government. The increased involvement of Kenyan and Ethiopian military forces, as part of AMISOM, in the conflict had pushed al-Shabab fighters even further into interior Somalia, particularly to rural areas in the south. Beyond military help from AMISOM, logistical support from the U.S. government, which was stepped up after President Obama's President, has helped the Somali government fight al-Shabab.

The group's defeat is predicated not just on military strategy but also on backing it from the forces of power in Somalia's clan-driven society. al-Shabab still has the capacity and wherewithal to carry out terrorist acts as it is emboldened and aided by disunity within Somalia's society. The country has been slowly limping back from a state of anarchy that began in the 1980s, with warlords ruling various parts of the country; now it has a functional presidential government. It was the long spell of anarchy that enabled al-Shabab to attain a position of prominence as an offshoot of the conservative Islamic Courts Union, which promised a semblance of order through the implementation of Shari'a law and the capacity to fill a vacuum in governance. Early this year, President Mohamed Abdullahi Mohamed was elected through an indirect polling process by a national council of parliamentarians nominated by senior elders. The state of civil war prevented the conduct of elections through universal adult franchise, but the Somali President seems to carry a positive reputation among the people. It is vital that he capitalises on this beginning.

1 Securing Somalia

Date : 17th October, 2017

The deadly attack in Mogadishu is a reminder that state-building must be accelerated. In the deadliest terrorist attack in Somalia, an explosives-laden truck collided with a fuel tanker in Mogadishu, killing more than 300 people and injuring many more. Mogadishu has seen a number of attacks and suicide bombings on “soft targets”, mostly hotels and restaurants, and military targets orchestrated by the terrorist group al-Shabaab in recent years, but none as horrific as this one. The Islamist organisation has not yet claimed responsibility for the attacks but government spokespersons have blamed the al-Qaeda-allied group. A weakened Al-Shabaab has managed to revive itself as a guerrilla force lately. Reports suggest that it has not claimed responsibility for Sunday’s attacks as yet because of the scale of the toll, as it did not anticipate the truck colliding with a fuel tanker. If it is indeed al-Shabaab’s doing, it would signal a dangerous reversal. Somalia must immediately work towards building a sense of civic solidarity among the various clans in the country and use the popular revulsion following the bombing to isolate al-Shabaab and its backers. Al-Shabaab had retreated from Mogadishu in August 2011 following intense joint offensives led by the African Union Mission in Somalia (AMISOM) and the Somali federal government. The increased involvement of Kenyan and Ethiopian military forces, as part of AMISOM, in the conflict had pushed al-Shabaab fighters even further into interior Somalia, particularly to rural areas in the south. Beyond military help from AMISOM, logistical support from the U.S. government, which was stepped up after Donald Trump became President, has helped the Somali government fight al-Shabaab.

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1 Securing Somalia

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Yet the group's defeat is predicated not just on military strategy but also on isolating it from the levers of power in Somalia's clan-driven society. Al-Shabaab still has the capacity and wherewithal to carry out terror attacks as it is emboldened and aided by divisions within Somali society. The country has been slowly limping back from a state of anarchy that began in the 1990s, with warlords controlling various parts of the country; now it has a functional presidential government. It was the long spell of anarchy that enabled al-Shabaab to attain a position of prominence as an offshoot of the conservative Islamic Courts Union, which promised a semblance of order through the implementation of Sharia law and the capacity to fill a vacuum in governance. Early this year, President Mohamed Abdullahi Mohamed was elected through an indirect polling process by an electoral college of parliamentarians nominated by society elders. The state of civil war prevented the conduct of elections through universal adult franchise, but the Somali President seems to carry a positive reputation among the people. It is vital that he capitalises on this beginning.





NEWS REPORT

DEATH TOLL IN MOGADISHU

- More than 300 people were killed by twin bomb explosions in Mogadishu.
- The blasts struck at two busy junctions in the heart of the capital city.
- Several experts said that the truck was probably carrying at least 500 kg of explosives.
- The blast occurred at a junction in Hodan, a busy commercial district, which has many shops, hotels and businesses.

WHAT IS AL-SHABAAB?



- 1 It is the Islamist Militant group.
- 2 It is an ally to Al-Qaeda.
- 3 It has carried out a string of attacks in neighbouring Kenya also.
- 4 It means 'The Youth' in Arabic.
- 5 It advocates the Saudi inspired Wahhabi version of Islam, while most Somalis are Sufis.
- 6 It imposed strict version of sharia in areas under its control including stoning to death, woman accused of adultery and amputating the hands of the thieves.
- 7 Although it lost control in most towns and cities, they still dominate many rural areas.

IS AL-SHABAAB RESPONSIBLE?

- 1 Al-Shabaab began insurgency operations in 2007.
- 2 It has not claimed responsibility, but the method and type of attack is increasingly used by the al Qaeda-linked organisation.
- 3 It stages regular attacks in the capital and other parts of the country.
- 4 Although the group claims it targets the government and security forces, it has detonated large bombs in crowded public areas before.

- 5 It has sometimes not claimed responsibility for bombings, because of the fear of big public backlash.
- 6 It is waging an insurgency against Somalia's UN-backed government and its African Union allies in a bid to impose its own strict interpretation of Islam.





MORE ON AL-SHABAAB AND SOMALIA



- 1** Al-Shabaab is the offshoot of the Conservative Islamic Courts Union.
- 2** The divisions in Somalian Society are quite evident.
- 3** Different clans control various parts of the Country.
- 4** The State of the civil war prevented the conduct of Elections through Universal Franchise.
- 5** The President was elected through an indirect polling process by an Electoral College of Parliamentarians nominated by society elders.

Somalian President seems to carry a positive reputation among the people. It is vital that he capitalizes on this beginning

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